



Held, Not Escalated: Coding the Library Front Desk's Disposal-Tier Register Against Six Rounds of Physical Stock-Take

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Abstract. The University Library's front-desk Lost & Found operates under a four-stage disposal-tier register — Hold, Escalate, Release, Dispose — that assigns every logged item a place on a published retention timetable before it may be acted on. We report a fourteen-week field study cross-referencing the register's own tier assignments against a hand-coded physical audit of the same items, conducted by two independent coders, together with the taxonomy front-desk staff say they actually apply ($n = 9$ staff interviewed; $n = 214$ items logged across six stock-take rounds). The register reports a rising share of items cleared to Release or Dispose across the term; the physical audit finds the substantial majority of those same items still sitting in Hold past their notional retention window, a gap that widens with each round. Interviews trace the divergence to a workaround the register cannot see: staff facing a stalled supervisor sign-off re-log an ageing item as newly received rather than decline its disposal, resetting the Hold clock without ever completing a tier transition. An ablation collapsing the four-stage sign-off to a single supervisor approval changes median time-to-disposal by two days (n.s.); we retain the four-stage structure for completeness. The findings suggest that what the disposal process reliably keeps current is the register, not the tub.

Introduction

Every campus front desk accumulates a residue of things nobody comes back for: umbrellas, single gloves, water bottles, phone chargers, on one documented occasion a single shoe. At the University Library, this residue is not left to accumulate informally. It is governed. A four-stage disposal-tier register — Hold, Escalate, Release, Dispose — assigns each logged item a tier, a notional retention window, and, for the final two tiers, a required supervisor sign-off, before Facilities may act on it (see Method, Table 1). The register is audited annually and its tier definitions are published as a standing procedure, not an informal convention.

Disposal governance of this kind is easy to overlook as a research object precisely because it works in miniature: the instrument is legible, the categories are few, and the stakes of a misclassified glove are low. That legibility is what makes

the register a clean site for a broader question that applies well beyond a lost-property tub — whether a classification system's own record of its operation can be trusted as evidence that the operation is occurring. Individual hesitation to discard is well documented at the level of a single desk drawer [1]; archival science asks a version of the same question at the level of a whole records schedule [2]; organisational-change research asks it of the inertia that keeps an outdated default in place after a nominal decision to move on [3], [4]. We ask it of a plastic tub governed not by one person's hesitation but by four published tiers and a supervisor sign-off.

We report a fourteen-week field study at the Library's front desk, cross-referencing the disposal-tier register's own logged assignments against a hand-coded physical audit of the same items across six stock-take rounds, together with semi-structured interviews with the front-

desk staff who apply the taxonomy day to day. Our contributions:

- We build and validate a taxonomy that operationalises the register’s four published tiers into a coding scheme two independent raters can apply to a physical item with substantial agreement.
- We show that the register’s reported tier composition and a same-day physical audit diverge, and that the divergence widens over the term rather than narrowing.
- We trace the divergence, via interview, to a specific front-desk workaround, and show in an ablation that the register’s four-stage sign-off structure is not the source of the delay the workaround exists to route around.

The remainder of the paper: Related work situates the register alongside other classification systems whose record of their own operation outruns the operation itself; Method describes the taxonomy, the audit protocol, and the interviews; Results reports the register/audit divergence and the ablation; Discussion and Limitations follow.

Related work

Classification systems accrue a life of their own once installed, and the record they produce can diverge from the world they describe without the system itself registering the gap [5], [6] — a dynamic we take as generalising here from a poorly-known instrument to a poorly-known plastic tub. Archival science treats the distance between a published retention schedule and what a review cycle actually preserves as a first-order appraisal problem, shaped in practice by factors the formal schedule does not itself capture [2]. Organisational research on status quo bias offers a mechanism for why: once a default is installed, the cost of actively cancelling it is felt more sharply than the cost of letting it silently persist, a mechanism recent organisational-change scholarship treats as something change leaders must actively work around rather than something a stated intention to change dissolves on its own [3], [4]. A parallel literature on sunk-cost reasoning finds a related asymmetry in decisions to terminate rather than merely maintain a project, arguing that termination requires a discrete, effortful act that continuation does not [7].

Closer to our field site, economic research on unclaimed property finds that the friction of the formal claims process shapes whether eligible owners ever recover unclaimed property, independent of the property’s value [8], and the charity-retail literature documents an adjacent pattern on the disposal side: donated goods a shop cannot process in time for resale routinely exceed what any formal write-off procedure accounts for [9]. Screen-level bureaucracy research documents how frontline staff exercise discretion through what they choose to record rather than what they choose to do, when the recording system itself is the point of friction [10] — the discretion our interviews document is the same shape, exercised on paper rather than a screen.

Method

Field site. The University Library’s front desk maintains a single Lost & Found receptacle for items handed in by patrons or recovered by cleaning staff. Every item is logged at intake with a tag number, a one-line description, and an initial tier assignment; the register requires no re-logging unless an item changes tier. The four published tiers are summarised in Table 1.

Tier	Code	Definition	Window
1	Hold	At-desk, claimable on a matching description	0–21 days
2	Escalate	Flagged for higher value or identifying marks; secure storage pending an owner trace	21–45 days
3	Release	Approved for charity donation	45–60 days, sign-off req.
4	Dispose	Approved for disposal or recycling	60+ days, sign-off req.

Table 1: The disposal-tier register’s four published tiers, reproduced verbatim from the current retention schedule.

Physical audit. Across a fourteen-week term we conducted six stock-take rounds (weeks 1, 3, 5, 8, 11, 14), each a full physical inventory

of the receptacle and its overflow shelf, cross-referenced by tag number against the register's live tier field for the same item on the same date. Two coders independently assigned a physical-audit tier to every present item using the published tier definitions alone, without consulting the register; disagreements were adjudicated by a third rater. Agreement was substantial (Gwet's AC1 = 0.81), consistent with reported advantages of AC1 over Cohen's kappa in high-prevalence category distributions of exactly this kind [11], and consistent with a coding-scheme protocol previously validated at this institution for another single-field logging system [12]. A total of 214 items were logged across the six rounds (net of items claimed or newly deposited between rounds).

Interviews. We conducted semi-structured interviews with nine front-desk staff (a rotating roster covering all shift patterns) about how they apply the four tiers in practice, following coding challenges documented for functional-language interview data of this kind [13]. Interviews were transcribed, coded independently by two of the authors against an inductive scheme, and discussed to consensus; we report the scheme's dominant category in Results.

Ablation. To test whether the register's four-stage sign-off structure is itself the source of any observed delay, we compare time-to-disposal decision for the standard four-stage pathway against a single-supervisor-approval pilot the Library ran concurrently on a fast-tracked subset of higher-value electronics (n = 11 per arm), matched on intake week.

Results

Register vs. audit. Figure 1 shows the register's own reported tier composition across the six stock-take rounds. Read on its own, the register describes a disposal pipeline working as designed: the Hold share falls from 78% in round 1 to 47% in round 6, while Release and Dispose together rise from 8% to 42% over the same period.

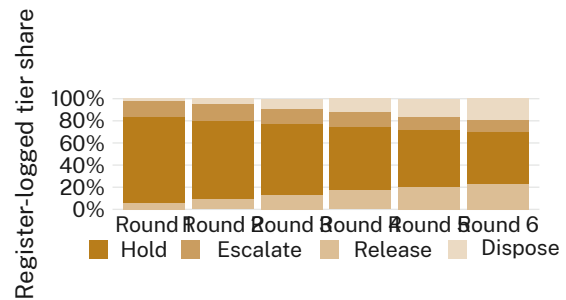


Figure 1: The register's own logged tier composition, round 1 to round 6: Hold falls from 78% to 47% as Release and Dispose rise from 8% to 42%.

Figure 2 plots the same rounds' register-reported Hold share against the physical audit's Hold share for the identical tagged items. By round 6, the register logs 47% of items as still in Hold; the same-day physical audit finds 94% of all logged items in the receptacle or its overflow shelf, a divergence that widens monotonically from round 1's 3 percentage points. No item physically absent from the desk area was ever coded to a lower audit tier than its registered one; the divergence runs in one direction only, register optimistic relative to audit.

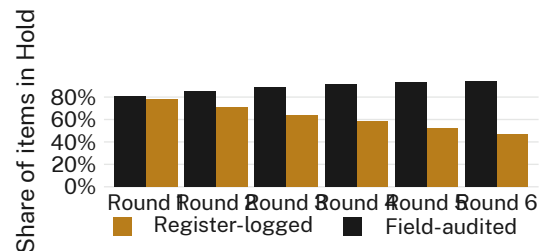


Figure 2: Register-logged vs. field-audited Hold share by round: 47% vs. 94% by round 6, up from a 3-point gap in round 1.

Interviews. Nine front-desk interviews converged on a single dominant account: staff report that a Release or Dispose sign-off frequently stalls awaiting supervisor availability, and that an item held past its Hold window with no sign-off pending becomes, in the words of the coding scheme's most-cited category, "awkward to have sitting there" on the intake shelf. The workaround staff describe is to re-log the item as newly received — a new tag number, a fresh 21-day Hold window — rather than push a stalled sign-off or leave the item visibly overdue. This action is indistinguishable in the register from a genuine new intake; it is the source of the

gap in Figure 2, and it is invisible to any audit of the register alone.

Ablation. Figure 3 compares days-to-disposal-decision for the standard four-stage sign-off against the single-supervisor-approval pilot. Medians are 34 and 36 days respectively (Mann-Whitney U, n.s.); the interquartile ranges overlap almost completely. Collapsing three of the four stages into one changes the outcome staff describe as the actual bottleneck by two days in the pilot's favour, well within the variation either pathway shows on its own. We retain the four-stage structure for completeness, consistent with the register's function as a record of tier assignments rather than, on this evidence, a determinant of how quickly one is reached.

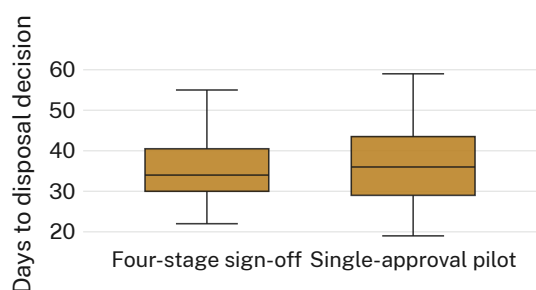


Figure 3: Days to disposal decision, four-stage sign-off vs. single-supervisor-approval pilot: medians 34 vs. 36 days (n.s.).

Discussion

The register is not wrong about anything it logs; each entry is a true record of a tier a staff member assigned at a point in time. What it cannot represent is a re-intake performed to avoid completing a stalled sign-off, because a re-intake and a genuine new arrival produce an identical register entry. The instrument's blind spot is structural, not a matter of staff carelessness or a register design that a revised form would fix: any single-field record of current status will absorb a status-avoiding action as if it were a status-confirming one [5], [10].

The ablation's null result reframes what the four-stage structure is actually protecting. It does not appear to protect against premature disposal — a single approval reaches the same outcome on the same timeline — but it does supply, at each stage, an entry in the register that a workaround can point to as pending. A shorter pathway would not necessarily shorten the queue; it might simply remove the record staff currently

use to justify not yet declining a disposal they have not yet approved. Consistent with recent findings that unnecessary procedural stages persist independent of their measured effect on outcomes [14], the register's currency, on this evidence, tracks its own bureaucratic legibility rather than the state of the tub it describes.

Limitations

Our physical audit covers one front desk across one fourteen-week term; the disposal-tier register is used, with the same four published tiers, at two further campus service points we did not audit, and we cannot claim the same divergence holds there, though the register's structure gives no reason to expect otherwise. The ablation's fast-track pilot was not randomised — items were assigned by staff judgement of value — which limits the causal claim we can draw from a null result to the population of items staff considered fast-track-eligible; a null on a harder-to-move subset would, if anything, understate how little the four-stage structure contributes. Interview coding relied on two raters rather than the full front-desk roster, though the consensus we report was unanimous among those interviewed.

Conclusion

A four-stage disposal-tier register, publicly documented and internally audited, reports a Lost & Found working steadily through its backlog. A physical count of the same items finds the backlog essentially undiminished, and an ablation finds the register's own elaborated structure contributes nothing measurable to how quickly an item actually moves. The gap is not a failure of the register to record what happened; it is a record of exactly what happened, performed by staff routing around a stalled sign-off in the only direction the register allows. Future work might apply the same audit-against-register design to the two campus service points sharing this taxonomy, and to the university's other single-field logging systems; this School's registry-scale work already finds a structurally similar pattern, where records of intended retirement do not track what is actually retired [15].

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